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# St. Paul reopens debate on use of Flock Safety cameras

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## St. Paul police flock camera debate



St. Paul police and civil rights advocates shared differing perspectives on the use of Flock Safety cameras, a controversial surveillance tool that has gained scrutiny since the start of Operation Metro Surge.

Flock contracts with law enforcement and private entities to operate its national network of more than 100,000 automated license plate readers. The cameras constantly scan license plates of passing vehicles, and Flock says its devices do not use facial recognition technology.

More than 100 agencies across Minnesota currently partner with Flock, according to data from the state's Bureau of Criminal Apprehension, but some cities, such as Columbia Heights and Brooklyn Park, have canceled those contracts, citing concerns that data was being shared with federal immigration agencies.

Proponents, meanwhile, argue the cameras are another tool for law enforcement to find criminals and that state law restricts what data can be shared with outside agencies.

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During a meeting of the St. Paul City Council's Public Safety Committee on Wednesday, St. Paul Police Department officials said every use of the technology is limited, documented and audited.

"Public safety and constitutional rights are not competing values. They must exist together," SPPD Deputy Chief Kurt Hallstrom said. "The standard we apply is simple: If a technology cannot be used lawfully, transparently and accountably, we should not be using it."

SPPD Sr. Cmdr. Ryan Murphy added that the department's license plate reader data is not shared outside of Minnesota, and no searches had been performed by out-of-state agencies over the past six months.

SPPD uses two Flock license plate readers, both near the intersection of Kellogg Avenue and Smith Street. The city's contract with Flock runs through 2028.

John Boehler, policy director for the American Civil Liberties Union of Minnesota, urged council members to consider stronger regulations on how surveillance technologies are used.

Those proposals ranged from canceling the city's contract with Flock entirely to opting into the company's optional transparency portals, which include information on each agency's policies for collecting data and which agencies are granted access to that data.

Boehler also recommended an end to sharing data with any jurisdiction that has signed a 287(g) agreement to assist with federal immigration enforcement. Eight counties and two cities in Minnesota have entered into such partnerships.

"What those agencies do with the data after they receive it from SPPD, they're obligated under state law to follow those state practices, but there is nothing practically preventing them from sharing the data," Boehler said.

No changes were made to St. Paul's Flock contract on Wednesday, but council members made it clear the debate is far from over as they weigh privacy, transparency and public safety needs.



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